

Attachment 7

Other Materials Provided to Participants

To Renounce Liberty? A Public-Goods Experiment on (Un)Democratic Reversal

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This attachment reproduces the substantive participant-facing instructions, checks, expectation items, final questionnaire, and debriefing implemented in oTree. Dynamic values such as the current round, proposal, rate, and payoff are inserted by the software. Research-only solo-testing controls are not shown in production.

Opening instructions

The opening screens identify Janne Tukiainen, Professor at the Turku School of Economics, University of Turku, as Principal Investigator and contact (janne.tukiainen@utu.fi; +358 50 308 3620). They explain that the study lasts approximately 60 minutes. The consent screen states that PCRC retains identifying information for recruitment and payment, researchers receive only coded data, and PCRC deletes the identity-to-code link after payment. It also notes that coded data may be retained for compatible future scientific research.

Imagine that you live in a society where public services have been under serious strain for a long time. Parliament has failed to pass a budget for eight months, healthcare waiting times have doubled, and planning for public services has stalled.

During the experiment, you and the other participants are the citizens of this society. You make decisions about a public-services fund. Points you keep count toward your payoff. Points that remain in the fund create group points shared equally among five citizens.

There are twenty paid rounds in two blocks of ten. In each round, participants choose whether a selected person's proposal requires group approval or takes effect directly. The method selected by at least three participants is used. The software then chooses a participant from those who have served least often, breaking ties randomly.

Under **Group approval required**, the other four citizens see the complete proposal and at least three must approve. If rejected, everyone chooses their own fund allocation. Under **Decision takes effect directly**, the proposal is implemented without that approval vote. Results and individual payoffs are then shown. Ten participants remain in one matching set and are reshuffled into five-person groups after every round; identities are never shown.

After all rounds, one round from each block is randomly selected. Points earned in those two rounds determine a performance bonus of up to EUR 5, and a EUR 10 participation payment is added. More selected-round points produce a larger bonus. Practice decisions are unpaid. There is no automatic time limit; the laboratory manager monitors progress and may prompt delayed participants.

Unpaid practice

Participants practise three decisions:

1. **Make a proposal:** choose how many of each citizen's 20 points should enter the fund and whether up to 20 fund points move to the selected person's payoff. A transfer cannot exceed the amount placed in the fund.
2. **Approve or reject:** respond to an example in which every citizen would place 10 points in the fund and 5 fund points would move to the selected person's payoff.
3. **Allocation after rejection:** choose an individual allocation after being told that the other four citizens each place 10 points in the fund at the 1.50 rate.

Comprehension check

Participants answer all five items correctly before paid play. Incorrect answers return a brief explanation and another attempt.

1. **Who proposes the equal allocation under the two methods?**
 - A randomly selected person proposes the allocation under both methods. *[Correct]*
 - A selected person is used only when the decision takes effect directly.
2. **When group approval is required, how many of the four other citizens must approve?**
 - At least three of the four other citizens. *[Correct]*
 - At least two of the four other citizens.
 - All four other citizens.
3. **What happens when a proposal requiring group approval is rejected?**
 - Everyone chooses their own fund allocation. *[Correct]*
 - The proposal takes effect anyway.
4. **When a decision takes effect directly, can the other citizens reject the proposal before it is implemented?** Yes / No *[Correct: No]*
5. **Which paid round determines your game earnings from Block 1?**
 - Every round.
 - Only the randomly selected round. *[Correct]*
 - Only Round 10.

Block 1 information

Every fund point left after any transfer creates 1.50 group points under Group approval required and 2.50 under Decision takes effect directly. If an approval-required proposal is rejected, participants make individual allocations at the 1.50 rate. The selected person may propose the same allocation and transfer under either method.

Block 2 updates

Each ten-person matching set sees one of the following screens after completing Block 1:

Conditions improve. Parliament has passed a budget, healthcare waiting times are falling, and planning for public services has resumed. As part of this recovery, every fund point under Group approval required now creates 2.50 group points. Under Decision takes effect directly, every point left in the fund creates 2.50 group points.

Conditions remain under strain. Parliament has still not passed a budget, healthcare waiting times remain high, and planning for public services remains stalled. Under Group approval required, every fund point creates 1.50 group points. Under Decision takes effect directly, every point left in the fund creates 2.50 group points.

In both updates, the decision rules remain the same: the software selects the proposer after the method ballot; the proposal either requires three approvals from the other four citizens or takes effect directly; rejection returns the group to individual allocations.

Unpaid expectation questions

These questions appear before Block 1 Round 10 and before Block 2 Rounds 1 and 10. Participants enter their best estimates; answers do not affect payment.

1. If group approval is required, how many points do you expect to earn? [0–60]
2. If the selected person's decision takes effect directly, how many points do you expect to earn? [0–60]
3. How many fund points do you expect the selected person to propose moving to their own payoff?

[0–20]

Final questionnaire

All paid decisions are complete before these items appear.

1. How serious did the public-service situation in Block 1 seem?
Not serious / Slightly serious / Moderately serious / Serious / Very serious
2. Compared with Block 1, how did the public-service situation in Block 2 seem?
Much worse / Somewhat worse / No change / Somewhat better / Much better
3. After these rounds, how well can the group support public services when the selected person's proposal requires group approval?
Very low / Low / Moderate / High / Very high
4. After these rounds, how high is the risk that the usual limits on a leader's power will be seriously weakened?
Very low / Low / Moderate / High / Very high

For each statement below, participants use a slider from 1 (strongly disagree) to 7 (strongly agree):

5. The current situation justifies allowing the selected person to act without group approval.
6. More effective public services are worth giving up the approval vote in the current situation.
7. Citizens should retain an approval vote over binding group decisions, even if agreement can fail.
8. The leader should be allowed to require every citizen to put the same number of points in the public-services fund.
9. I prefer requiring approval to letting a selected person implement an unwanted transfer.
10. Removing the approval vote creates risks that outweigh the current gains.
11. When public services work poorly, selected decision-makers need more freedom to act without further approval.

Debriefing

The study examines whether people use a group ballot to remove approval over a later binding decision and whether they subsequently vote to restore that approval. For some matching sets, public-service conditions improved and the two fund rates became equal; for others, the crisis and rate gap continued. Under both methods, the selected person could propose the same allocation and personal transfer; the difference was whether the other citizens could reject it.

No single choice is interpreted as evidence that a participant is corrupt, authoritarian, or opposed to democracy. Changing a choice is not treated as inconsistency. The study examines how institutional choices respond when public-service conditions and their material consequences change.